

Statistical Mechanics of Turing Machines

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1 Prior Works

The systems considered here consist of mobile finite-state machines that read and modify a shared tape. Their collective behavior connects several existing research programs: cellular automata, interacting turmites, algorithmic chemistry, deterministic walks in a writable environment, and nonequilibrium statistical mechanics. The distinction between these connections matters. Some references study nearly the same microscopic architecture; others supply observables or solution methods whose assumptions must be checked for the present dynamics.

1.1 Cellular automata, mobile automata, and rule-space surveys

Wolfram’s statistical-mechanical study of cellular automata [1] is a methodological precedent for sampling simple deterministic rules, evolving random initial conditions, and comparing the resulting organization. It demonstrates that local binary rules can generate structured statistical behavior without an equilibrium energy function. In a cellular automaton, the sites update through a prescribed spatial rule; in the present simulations, the moving heads determine where updates occur. Their positions therefore form an additional dynamical field.

A New Kind of Science [2] extends systematic experimentation to Turing machines and mobile automata, including generalized mobile automata with multiple active cells. These examples motivate the spacetime zoos and comparisons between blank and random tapes. The associated 2003 collection of open problems [3] calls for systematic studies of simple Turing machines, nonblank initial conditions, and the relation between active-cell density and behavioral complexity. Those historical questions closely match the present program, but their appearance in that collection does not establish their current research status. Wolfram’s later multiway Turing machines [4] concern branching computational

histories under nondeterministic rules. Multiple branches are distinct from a population of heads simultaneously modifying a single tape.

1.2 Interacting turmites and shared-tape agents

Belgacem and Fatès [5] provide a direct spatial precedent by studying multiple Langton turmites on a shared binary lattice. They compare synchronous updates, a fixed sequential order, and random sequential orders, together with different policies for spatial conflicts. Their experiments show that collective patterns depend on the scheduling and interaction conventions, even when the individual agent rule stays fixed. This supports treating update order and collision resolution as model parameters in our simulations. Their model is two-dimensional and includes agent orientation and movement-conflict policies, so its collective structures do not directly determine the behavior of the one-dimensional rules studied below.

Polhill and collaborators [6] explicitly consider a population of Turing machines reading and writing the same tape. Their thought experiment studies prediction when transition tables, initial head states and positions, and execution schedules are hidden. It establishes a close architectural precedent, while addressing inference and computability rather than deriving stationary measures or transport laws. In particular, its discussion of noncomputable schedules should be distinguished from the reproducible, seeded random schedules used in numerical experiments here.

1.3 Algorithmic chemistry and Fontana’s Turing gas

Fontana’s algorithmic chemistry [7] treats an ensemble of symbolic functions as interacting objects. In this “Turing gas,” expressions derived from the lambda calculus act on one another to generate new expressions, and the population develops cooperative organizations. This supplies an early precedent for studying collective behavior in a population of programs.

Fontana and Buss [8] subsequently analyze the emergence of reproducing and self-maintaining organizations in this abstract chemistry. Their work suggests examining which interaction patterns persist across different initial populations. The correspondence to our model is conceptual: their reacting objects are themselves programs, and reactions change the program population. Here the sampled transition tables remain fixed and the shared spatial tape carries the evolving record of interactions. Thus algorithmic chemistry motivates questions about collective organization, but its reaction rules cannot be imported as the dynamics of the present gas.

1.4 Eulerian walkers and rotor-router theory

The symbol-flipping one-state machine has a particularly close connection to rotor walks: successive occupied visits alternate the departure direction at a site. Priezzhev and collaborators [9] study walkers that modify local arrows and, on

open graphs, are replaced after absorption. Their particle addition operators connect the stationary problem to the Abelian sandpile model. Holroyd and collaborators [10] give a systematic treatment of rotor routing, its Abelian properties, and the relation between recurrent rotor configurations and rooted spanning trees.

These results apply directly to the isolated-particle excursions used in the dilute boundary-driven calculation in Appendix A.4, after matching the convention for whether a rotor records the last or next departure. In particular, the recurrent empty tapes $1^k 0^{L-k}$ are the one-dimensional version of acyclic rotor configurations with absorbing boundaries. The dilute calculation should therefore be understood in the context of established rotor-router theory, rather than as an unrelated mechanism.

Klasing and collaborators [11] analyze several agents sharing a rotor environment on a ring, obtaining rigorous cover-time and long-time return-time results. A decisive microscopic difference is that their rotor advances once per departing agent: two agents at one site can leave in opposite directions. In our synchronous symbol-flipping model, the tape flips once per *occupied site*, and all particles in a stack depart together. Stacks that meet at one site merge permanently. The published multi-agent bounds and Abelian arguments therefore do not automatically extend to this coalescing dynamics. They identify useful tools and solvable sectors, while leaving a distinct problem at finite stack density.

1.5 Quantifying tape structure and relaxation

Computational mechanics provides observables that distinguish visible organization from simple changes in symbol frequency. Shalizi and collaborators [12] develop local sensitivity and statistical-complexity filters for detecting coherent structures in spatiotemporal systems. Applied to cellular automata, these reveal domains and localized structures without assuming their shapes in advance. For the present spacetime plots, such filters suggest a way to quantify traveling structures and collision regions, supplementing head trajectories and tape density.

Feldman, McTague, and Crutchfield [13] compare processes using complexity-entropy diagrams, combining randomness with stored structure. This is relevant because a tape with equal numbers of zeros and ones can still be periodic or strongly correlated. Useful measurements here would include block entropies, entropy rates, excess entropy, spatial correlations, and correlations between head states and local symbols. Estimating them requires specifying the ensemble and checking stationarity; pooling different machine rules or different ages of a relaxing system can otherwise obscure the distinction between within-run fluctuations and variation across runs. Convergence of these observables would provide evidence of statistical relaxation, but would not by itself identify a Gibbs ensemble or a temperature.

1.6 Boundary-driven stationary states and thermodynamic costs

The review by Buča, Klobas, and Prosen [14] describes exact nonequilibrium stationary states of the reversible Rule-54 cellular automaton with stochastic boundaries, including patch and matrix-product representations, relaxation modes, and current fluctuations. It supplies a concrete strategy for the boundary-driven attempt below: specify the reservoirs, construct the Markov operator, solve small systems, and search for a representation whose local algebra verifies stationarity. Its exact formulas depend on that model’s microscopic structure. Our synchronous coalescence rule does not inherit those formulas merely because it also admits a cellular-automaton description. The transferable object is the stationary-state problem and the methods used to attack it.

Strasberg and collaborators [15] address a different thermodynamic question by constructing stochastic physical implementations of Turing machines with consistent entropy production. Their results concern the cost of performing computation. A statistical ensemble of abstract shared-tape machines does not yet specify the energy levels, physical transition rates, or reservoirs needed to assign heat and work. For this reason, tape Shannon entropy and state-distribution entropy should initially be treated as information-theoretic observables, not identified with physical entropy production.

1.7 Scope of the present problem

Together, these references establish precedents for computational populations, agents coupled through writable media, and statistical descriptions of deterministic local dynamics. Within the works reviewed here, we have not identified a general stationary or hydrodynamic theory covering arbitrary randomly sampled transition tables under the present shared-tape collision rules; this is a statement about the scope of this review, not a claim of priority.

A useful formulation separates randomness in the initial tape and head states from randomness in the transition tables. Sampling a table once and retaining it defines quenched algorithmic disorder; resampling it during evolution would define a different process. The closed-system limit should specify particle number N , tape length L , and density N/L , while an open-system limit must also fix how reservoir rates scale with L . The one-state symbol-flipping model below isolates a tractable part of this broader program: it connects directly to rotor walks in the single-stack sector and introduces irreversible coalescence when several stacks interact synchronously.

2 Langton’s Ant

The first simple example we start with is Langton’s ant, or turmite, on a one dimensional line. The rules are simple.

Read	Write	Move
0	1	<i>Left</i>
1	0	<i>Right</i>

Let us define the tape at time t at position x as $V_t(x) \in \{0, 1\}$, and the number of turmites at position x and time t as $n_t(x)$. The update rules for turmites which are not restricted in their motion is

$$V_{t+1}(x) = V_t(x) + \Theta(n_t(x)) (1 - 2V_t(x)) \quad (1)$$

$$n_{t+1}(x) = (1 - V_t(x+1)) n_t(x+1) + V_t(x-1) n_t(x-1) \quad (2)$$

A scratchpad

A.1 Exact synchronous equations for the symbol-flipping machine

The rule considered above is

$$0 \longrightarrow (1, L), \quad 1 \longrightarrow (0, R). \quad (3)$$

It is useful to distinguish the number of turmites at a site from the Boolean event that the site is occupied. Define

$$I_t(x) = \mathbf{1}_{\{n_t(x) > 0\}}. \quad (4)$$

Thus, throughout this section, $\Theta(n)$ is understood to equal zero at $n = 0$ and one for $n > 0$.

Under synchronous updating, all turmites first read the tape at time t , then propose their writes and moves. Since all turmites at a given site read the same symbol, their write proposals agree. The exact tape update is therefore

$$V_{t+1}(x) = V_t(x) + I_t(x) [1 - 2V_t(x)] \quad (5)$$

$$= V_t(x) \oplus I_t(x), \quad (6)$$

where $\oplus$ denotes addition modulo two.

A turmite at $x+1$ enters x if it reads zero and moves left, whereas a turmite at $x-1$ enters x if it reads one and moves right. Consequently, the exact number update is

$$\boxed{n_{t+1}(x) = [1 - V_t(x+1)] n_t(x+1) + V_t(x-1) n_t(x-1).} \quad (7)$$

This agrees with the number update in the main text. If the equation is instead written for the increment $n_{t+1}(x) - n_t(x)$, its right-hand side must include the additional loss term $-n_t(x)$.

To display number conservation, define the rightward current across the bond $x + \frac{1}{2}$ by

$$J_t(x + \tfrac{1}{2}) = V_t(x) n_t(x) - [1 - V_t(x+1)] n_t(x+1). \quad (8)$$

The number equation then takes the continuity form

$$n_{t+1}(x) - n_t(x) = J_t\left(x - \frac{1}{2}\right) - J_t\left(x + \frac{1}{2}\right). \quad (9)$$

On an infinite tape with suitable decay, or on a periodic tape with all site indices understood modulo L , this implies

$$\sum_x n_{t+1}(x) = \sum_x n_t(x) = N. \quad (10)$$

A.2 Rotor representation

Define a binary rotor field

$$\sigma_t(x) = 2V_t(x) - 1 \in \{-1, +1\}, \quad (11)$$

where -1 sends a stack left and $+1$ sends it right. The coupled equations become

$$\sigma_{t+1}(x) = (-1)^{I_t(x)} \sigma_t(x), \quad (12)$$

$$n_{t+1}(x) = \frac{1 - \sigma_t(x+1)}{2} n_t(x+1) + \frac{1 + \sigma_t(x-1)}{2} n_t(x-1). \quad (13)$$

The first equation says that an occupied site reverses its rotor exactly once, independently of the number of turmites in the stack.

The tape and the support of the turmite distribution form a closed Boolean system. In particular,

$$\boxed{I_{t+1}(x) = [I_t(x-1) \wedge V_t(x-1)] \vee [I_t(x+1) \wedge \neg V_t(x+1)]}. \quad (14)$$

Together with $V_{t+1} = V_t \oplus I_t$, this is a deterministic, nearest-neighbor four-state cellular automaton for (V_t, I_t) . The integer masses $n_t(x)$ can be transported after the Boolean dynamics have been solved.

Every occupied site sends its entire stack to one neighboring site. Two stacks that arrive at the same site merge and can never split again. Hence the number of occupied sites

$$K_t = \sum_x I_t(x) \quad (15)$$

is nonincreasing:

$$K_{t+1} \leq K_t. \quad (16)$$

This monotonic coalescence property is a useful simplification even though the conserved mass N need not decrease.

A.3 Odometer representation and a route to a solution

Introduce the site odometer

$$u_t(x) = \sum_{\tau=0}^{t-1} I_\tau(x), \quad (17)$$

which counts the number of time steps at which site x has been occupied. The tape can then be eliminated in favor of its initial condition:

$$\sigma_t(x) = \sigma_0(x)(-1)^{u_t(x)}. \quad (18)$$

For a single stack at position X_t , this gives the closed rotor-walk form

$$X_{t+1} = X_t + \sigma_0(X_t)(-1)^{u_t(X_t)}. \quad (19)$$

A possible route toward solving the many-turmite system is the following.

1. Solve the single-stack rotor walk in terms of its odometer, visited interval, and return times.
2. Classify two-stack scattering and determine the conditions for coalescence. On an even ring, each step changes position parity, so two stacks can occupy the same site at the same time only if their initial positions have the same parity.
3. Analyze the four-state cellular automaton (V, I) on small periodic rings by constructing its complete transition graph. This gives exact attractors, periods, traveling waves, and basin sizes without retaining the stack masses.
4. Use the fact that a deterministic system on a finite ring must eventually become periodic. A traveling orbit that advances by d sites in P time steps has the rational velocity

$$v = \frac{d}{P}. \quad (20)$$

This provides a possible explanation for the recurring rational velocities observed numerically.

5. Once the support dynamics and its coalescence events are known, propagate the conserved integer masses along those trajectories to recover $n_t(x)$ and the mass-weighted velocity distribution.

The other symbol-flipping one-state machine, $0 \rightarrow (1, R)$ and $1 \rightarrow (0, L)$, is obtained from the system above by the spatial reflection $x \mapsto -x$. Solving one rule therefore solves its mirror as well.

A.4 An attempt at a boundary-driven solution

The boundary-driven strategy is to keep the deterministic bulk rule and introduce randomness only through particle reservoirs. One then solves for a stationary probability distribution and its currents. The review by Buča, Klobas, and Prosen [14] illustrates this strategy using patch and matrix-product stationary states. Here we apply the general strategy to the symbol-flipping model itself. The results below include exact stationary identities, an existence and uniqueness argument, and a solution to leading order in the injection rates; an arbitrary-density closed-form stationary distribution remains to be found.

Choice of reservoirs and update convention. Take an interval $x = 1, \dots, L$, with $L \geq 2$. Particles leaving either end are absorbed. At each time step, independent variables

$$b_t^L \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\alpha), \quad b_t^R \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\beta) \quad (21)$$

inject one particle at the left and right endpoints, respectively. These variables are independent of the configuration and of previous injections. First the old particles read, flip, and move synchronously; the new particles are then added to the endpoints and first act on the next step. The reservoirs do not reset tape symbols. Other reservoir conventions define different open models and need not have the stationary state derived here.

With time subscripts suppressed on the right-hand sides, the boundary rules are

$$n_{t+1}(1) = (1 - V_2)n_2 + b_t^L, \quad (22)$$

$$n_{t+1}(L) = V_{L-1}n_{L-1} + b_t^R, \quad (23)$$

with Eq. (7) in the interior and $V_{t+1}(x) = V_x \oplus I_x$ everywhere. Injection into an already arriving stack adds mass without creating a second stack. In particular,

$$N_{t+1} - N_t = b_t^L + b_t^R - (1 - V_1)n_1 - V_L n_L. \quad (24)$$

A finite Markov problem for tape and support. Define the outgoing stack indicators

$$r_x = I_x V_x, \quad \ell_x = I_x (1 - V_x). \quad (25)$$

The closed support dynamics are

$$I_{t+1}(1) = b_t^L \vee \ell_2, \quad (26)$$

$$I_{t+1}(x) = r_{x-1} \vee \ell_{x+1}, \quad 2 \leq x \leq L-1, \quad (27)$$

$$I_{t+1}(L) = r_{L-1} \vee b_t^R. \quad (28)$$

Thus $s = (V, I)$ has 4^L possible values, although the full state (V, n) has unbounded integer masses. Let $F_{bc}(s)$ denote the Boolean update with boundary choices (b, c) and let

$$w_{bc} = \alpha^b (1 - \alpha)^{1-b} \beta^c (1 - \beta)^{1-c}. \quad (29)$$

The column-stochastic transition matrix and stationary equation are

$$P(s' | s) = \sum_{b,c=0}^1 w_{bc} \mathbf{1}_{\{s' = F_{bc}(s)\}}, \quad P\pi = \pi, \quad \sum_s \pi(s) = 1. \quad (30)$$

Different injection events can produce the same Boolean successor, so their probabilities must be added. This is an exact finite-size formulation; its exponential state count is the practical limitation.

Why the finite open system has a unique steady state. There is a useful decreasing potential when injection is switched off. Set

$$h_x = x(L + 1 - x), \quad a_x = L + 1 - 2x, \quad (31)$$

and define

$$\mathcal{Q}(V, I) = \sum_{x=1}^L h_x I_x + \sum_{x=1}^L [a_x V_x - \min(0, a_x)]. \quad (32)$$

Let $C_x = r_{x-1} \ell_{x+1}$, setting the incoming indicators outside the interval to zero. With no injection, direct substitution gives

$$\boxed{\mathcal{Q}_{t+1} - \mathcal{Q}_t = -K_t - \sum_{x=1}^L h_x C_x.} \quad (33)$$

Indeed, a departure in direction $\sigma_x = 2V_x - 1$ changes its h weight by $h_{x+\sigma_x} - h_x = -1 + a_x \sigma_x$, while the tape contribution changes by $-a_x \sigma_x$. Coalescence removes one additional h_x weight at each double arrival. Absorption is included by $h_0 = h_{L+1} = 0$. Since

$$0 \leq \mathcal{Q} \leq B_L, \quad B_L = \frac{L(L+1)(L+2)}{6} + \left\lfloor \frac{L^2}{2} \right\rfloor, \quad (34)$$

every configuration empties within B_L consecutive steps without injection, independently of its stack masses.

Emptying does not reset the tape, but a common empty configuration is accessible. Inject one particle from the left into an empty interval and wait for it to exit. If the first zero is at j , the particle travels to j , turns, and exits on the left; its final tape has its first j symbols equal to one and its remaining symbols unchanged. If all symbols were one, it exits on the right and leaves an all-zero tape. At most $L + 1$ such isolated injections therefore reach the empty all-zero configuration, denoted s_* . Each excursion takes at most $2L - 1$ moves.

For $0 < \alpha, \beta < 1$, all the required injection and no-injection events have positive probability. Every Boolean state can reach s_* , which also has a no-injection self-loop. Hence there is exactly one recurrent class, it is aperiodic, and π is unique. This argument does not require irreducibility on all 4^L states.

The same construction reaches $(V, n) = (0, 0)$ in a uniformly bounded number of steps, with a positive probability bounded below for fixed (L, α, β) , regardless of the initial masses. Repeated blocks thus give a geometric bound on the reset time. Since at most two particles enter per step, the full process also has a unique stationary distribution with finite mass moments. The bounds deteriorate with L and do not establish a thermodynamic-limit steady state.

Exact stationary identities and the first closure problem. Write $\langle \cdot \rangle$ for stationary expectation and $\kappa_x = \langle I_x \rangle$ for the stack density. Stationarity of the

tape gives a particularly simple identity:

$$0 = \langle V_{t+1}(x) - V_t(x) \rangle = \langle I_x(1 - 2V_x) \rangle, \quad \boxed{\langle r_x \rangle = \langle \ell_x \rangle = \frac{\kappa_x}{2}}. \quad (35)$$

Thus the symbol seen at an occupied site is unbiased in the stationary measure. This does not imply $\langle V_x \rangle = 1/2$: the tape at empty sites can be strongly polarized.

Using $a \vee b = a + b - ab$, the bulk support balance becomes

$$\boxed{\frac{\kappa_{x-1} - 2\kappa_x + \kappa_{x+1}}{2} = c_x, \quad c_x = \langle r_{x-1} \ell_{x+1} \rangle \geq 0.} \quad (36)$$

The mean stack profile is therefore discretely convex. Its rightward current is $j_{x+1/2} = (\kappa_x - \kappa_{x+1})/2$ and satisfies $j_{x-1/2} - j_{x+1/2} = c_x$. Independence of each fresh boundary draw gives the exact boundary conditions

$$\kappa_1 = \alpha + (1 - \alpha)\frac{\kappa_2}{2}, \quad \kappa_L = \beta + (1 - \beta)\frac{\kappa_{L-1}}{2}. \quad (37)$$

For $L = 2$, these close without any approximation:

$$\kappa_1 = \frac{2(2\alpha + \beta - \alpha\beta)}{3 + \alpha + \beta - \alpha\beta}, \quad \kappa_2 = \frac{2(\alpha + 2\beta - \alpha\beta)}{3 + \alpha + \beta - \alpha\beta}. \quad (38)$$

For larger systems, the unknown collision correlations c_x prevent a one-point closure. The replacement $c_x \approx \kappa_{x-1}\kappa_{x+1}/4$ is a possible mean-field approximation, not an exact consequence of the rotor balance.

Mass has a different balance: its stationary current J is constant across all bonds, with

$$J = \langle V_x n_x - (1 - V_{x+1})n_{x+1} \rangle, \quad (39)$$

$$J = \alpha - \langle (1 - V_1)n_1 \rangle = \langle V_L n_L \rangle - \beta. \quad (40)$$

Equal left and right *stack* departure rates do not imply equal *mass* departure rates: stack size can correlate with direction.

Exact finite-size mass observables without a mass cutoff. There is nevertheless a finite linear closure for first mass moments conditioned on the entire Boolean state. Let $T(V)$ route each column x to row $x + 2V_x - 1$, deleting it if the destination lies outside the interval. For injection event $e = (b, c)$, set $g_e = b\mathbf{e}_1 + c\mathbf{e}_L$. The full mass update is $n' = T(V)n + g_e$. Define the unnormalized vector

$$m_x(s) = \mathbb{E}[n_x \mathbf{1}_{\{(V,I)=s\}}]. \quad (41)$$

After solving Eq. (30), stationarity requires

$$m(s') = \sum_{s,e} w_e \mathbf{1}_{\{s'=F_e(s)\}} [T(V(s))m(s) + g_e \pi(s)]. \quad (42)$$

This is a linear system for at most $L4^L$ unknowns, with $m_x(s) = 0$ if $I_x(s) = 0$. Its homogeneous evolution transports only previously present mass, which is erased by a sufficiently long no-injection block. On these support-compatible coordinates its spectral radius is less than one, so the linear system has a unique solution. Then

$$\rho_x = \sum_s m_x(s), \quad J = \sum_s [V_x(s)m_x(s) - (1 - V_{x+1}(s))m_{x+1}(s)] \quad (43)$$

give the exact finite-size mass density and current. This bypasses a cutoff on stack size, although the Boolean state count remains exponential.

A controlled solution for rare injection. Set $\alpha = \epsilon a$, $\beta = \epsilon b$, with fixed $a, b > 0$, and take $\epsilon \rightarrow 0$ at fixed L . Injections are then separated by isolated single-particle excursions with probability tending to one. A naive expansion about a fixed empty tape would fail: at zero injection, all 2^L empty tapes are absorbing. The drive selects a measure on this degenerate set, which must be determined first.

The recurrent empty tapes under isolated boundary injections are

$$E_k = \underbrace{11 \cdots 1}_k \underbrace{00 \cdots 0}_{L-k}, \quad k = 0, \dots, L. \quad (44)$$

A left injection maps E_k to E_{k+1} , and a right injection maps it to E_{k-1} , with indices modulo $L+1$. This set is closed, and the left-injection construction above takes every other empty tape into it. On the slow time scale, the interface index has generator

$$(\mathcal{G}f)(k) = a[f(k+1) - f(k)] + b[f(k-1) - f(k)]. \quad (45)$$

Its stationary distribution is uniform, even when $a \neq b$. Because the waiting time for injection is independent of k , the physical-time stationary measure has the same leading weights:

$$\pi(V = E_k, I = 0) = \frac{1}{L+1} + O(\epsilon). \quad (46)$$

The tape is consequently correlated and polarized even at arbitrarily weak drive. For example,

$$\langle V_x \rangle = \frac{L+1-x}{L+1} + O(\epsilon), \quad (47)$$

$$\text{Cov}(V_x, V_y) = \frac{x(L+1-y)}{(L+1)^2} + O(\epsilon), \quad x \leq y. \quad (48)$$

The same excursion picture gives the particle densities. Averaged uniformly over E_k , a left-injected particle visits site x an average $2(L+1-x)/(L+1)$ times

before absorption. A right-injected particle has mean visit count $2x/(L+1)$. Multiplying by the injection rates yields

$$\boxed{\rho_x = \kappa_x + O(\epsilon^2) = \frac{2[\alpha(L+1-x) + \beta x]}{L+1} + O(\epsilon^2).} \quad (49)$$

The mean residence time of an isolated injected particle is L steps, and hence $\langle N \rangle = L(\alpha + \beta) + O(\epsilon^2)$. A left-injected particle exits on the right only from E_L ; a right-injected particle exits on the left only from E_0 . Therefore

$$\boxed{J = \frac{\alpha - \beta}{L+1} + O(\epsilon^2).} \quad (50)$$

These are fixed- L asymptotic statements. The coefficients hidden in the errors can grow with L ; in particular, overlap becomes relevant when the injection rate times the excursion duration is no longer small. The $1/(L+1)$ conductance is an exact leading dilute-limit result, not yet a proof of diffusive transport at finite density.

A matrix-product starting point and the remaining problem. The leading empty-tape distribution already has an exact bond-dimension-two matrix-product representation. In the physical basis (V, I) , take

$$A_{(1,0)} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad A_{(0,0)} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad A_{(v,1)} = 0, \quad (51)$$

with $\langle l | = (1, 0)$ and $|r\rangle = (1, 1)^\top$. Then

$$\pi^{(0)}(s) = \frac{1}{L+1} \langle l | A_{(V_1, I_1)} \cdots A_{(V_L, I_L)} | r \rangle \quad (52)$$

assigns unit unnormalized weight precisely to the $L+1$ tapes E_k with empty support. This supplies an explicit starting point for a perturbative matrix-product calculation rather than an unspecified ansatz.

At nonzero density, excursions overlap, stacks merge, and tape memory couples successive events. A next step is to calculate the $O(\epsilon^2)$ collision corrections using two injections, including both same-boundary and opposite-boundary events. In parallel, the finite-size stationary vectors from Eq. (30) can test whether a small matrix-product representation survives at finite drive. An ansatz must satisfy the actual local update and reservoir equations; no fixed bond dimension or Rule-54 cancellation algebra has been established for this model. Mass observables can then be obtained from Eq. (42) even if the full mass distribution is not explicitly known.

Checks on the calculation. The no-injection potential identity was verified on all 4^L Boolean configurations for $L = 2, \dots, 8$. Their maximal clearing times were 3, 7, 12, 18, 26, 37, 47 steps, respectively, all below B_L . The isolated-injection tape

maps were checked for every empty tape through $L = 10$. Numerical stationary solutions of the exact finite transition matrix at $(\alpha, \beta) = (0.37, 0.61)$ satisfied the rotor, boundary, and coalescence identities to better than 10^{-11} for $L = 2, \dots, 7$; the conditional mass equations gave spatially constant mass currents through $L = 6$. At $L = 3$, with $(a, b) = (0.37, 0.61)$ and $\epsilon = 0.02, 0.01, 0.005$, the discrepancies in Eqs. (49) and (50) scaled as $O(\epsilon^2)$. These checks support the derivations but do not replace an arbitrary-density solution.

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